

the power of the monarch in favor of that of the people, who, he said, must balance rights with duties, and should be able to decide the laws that govern their lives. The contributors to the *Encyclopédie* also promoted liberal values in economics. They were critical of fairs—where goods were sold by visiting dealers at the expense of local traders, who often had to close their businesses for the duration—and favored markets, which allowed local traders to meet the needs of the local population.

Ideas such as these spread across Europe. Conversations and debates on philosophical, political, and scientific subjects took place in the coffeehouses that had sprung up in English, French, German, and Dutch cities a century earlier. These coffeehouses now served as information-sharing hubs where men from all walks of life, including writers, politicians, philosophers, and scientists, could congregate to exchange views.

Into the light

In Europe, the Enlightenment movement, and the *Encyclopédie* itself, which helped promote its ideals, had a profound impact on social, political, and intellectual life. Its proponents believed that they were sweeping away an oppressive medieval worldview and ushering in a new era that they hoped would be characterized by freedom of thought, open-mindedness, and tolerance.

The Enlightenment's questioning, rational approach, and urgent demand for liberty, paved the way for the granting of new civil rights. The movement affected the policies of monarchical rulers, such as the freeing of serfs in the Holy Roman Empire in the 1780s. Monarchs who accepted Enlightenment values took on the movement's name, titling themselves Enlightened Despots. Enlightenment thought also provided the intellectual fuel for the French Revolution of 1789–1799—begun by citizens inspired by Enlightenment notions of individual freedom and equality—and the campaign to abolish the Atlantic slave trade in the 19th century.

Liberalism and other aspects of Enlightenment political philosophy began to influence leaders in many parts of the world when they came to draw up legal systems and establish rights for their citizens—most notably in the fledgling United States, whose Constitution (1787) adopted Montesquieu's idea of the separation of power into branches of government.

More generally, the movement promoted the pursuit of knowledge for its own sake and recognized that one person's quest for understanding could benefit the entire human race. ■



Voltaire

François-Marie Arouet, who chose to be known publicly by the name Voltaire, was one of the greatest writers and social activists of the Enlightenment, renowned for his wit and intelligence. He was born in Paris in 1694, and spent much of his long life there, although he traveled widely and spoke several languages. He was a hugely prolific writer, producing works in almost every literary genre: novels, plays, poems, essays, historical studies, and philosophical books as well as countless pamphlets.

Voltaire was an outspoken supporter of social reform, including the defense of civil liberties and freedom of religion and speech; he also denounced the hypocrisy of the political and religious establishment. This led to the censorship of some of his work, and also to short spells of imprisonment and periods of exile in England—after which he converted his experiences into an influential book, *Philosophical Letters on the English*—and Geneva, Switzerland, where he wrote his most famous work, the philosophical novella *Candide*.